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THE MEDIA BUSINESS

Publishing Esther B. Fein

Smaller books can be tactile, and even sensual, hinting at delights, and profits, ahead.

THE Itty Bitty Book Light now has the perfect companion: the itty bitty book. Inspired by the recent success of several books that have come out in a smaller, more compact format, publishers are now packaging more books, particularly novels, in trimmer size and are increasingly regarding this once-rare design as a standard option.

And customers are buying them. Two small-size novels are on the New York Times best-seller list next Sunday. "The Bridges of Madison County" (Warner) by Robert James Waller, in the No. 2 slot, which has been on the list for 32 weeks, much of that time in the No. 1 position, and "Einstein's Dreams" (Pantheon) by Alan Lightman, the No. 10 book.

Several other best-seller lists around the country include another book of this size, "Like Water for Chocolate" (Doubleday) by Laura Esquivel.

Publishers and booksellers say there are good reasons for the trend. Although the sizes vary by house, the average book tends to be about 9 3/4 inches by 6 1/2 inches, while the smaller books are about 7 3/4 inches by 4 3/4 inches. Books in the smaller sizes are more portable, easier to finish, usually cheaper — they range from about \$15 to \$18, compared with \$23 to \$25 for most novels — and they add a tactile, even a sensual element, to the experience of reading.

"Somehow, the size draws you into the book," said Stephen Rubin, president and publisher of Doubleday. "It's a cuddly size, and it is becoming the literary novel what foil and

embossing have been to the commercial novel, a signal of a kind of book."

Most people in publishing trace the current wave of small books to Alfred A. Knopf's spring 1991 publication of "Damage," Josephine Hart's erotic novel about the obsessive and tragic affair between a member of the British Parliament and his son's fiancée. The volume was small and exquisitely designed to look somewhat like a backgammon board, visually implying the book's theme that love and attraction can be a dangerous game.

Sonny Mehta, the president and editor in chief of Knopf, who also oversees Pantheon, is widely praised in the industry for appreciating the value of a book's visual effect and for assembling a design staff that regularly produces memorable covers.

"Damage" is certainly the granddaddy of these books," said Laurence J. Kirshbaum, president of Warner Books. "You have to give Sonny a lot of credit for realizing that size is a very important element in a book's design, equally as important as the cover art. It's a tremendous marketing device that in a sense makes these books seem bigger by making them physically smaller."

Mr. Mehta said he would "love to take credit" for the trend "but really can't." He said his library shelves hold many slim small volumes published decades ago, including a favorite copy of "Plutarch's Lives" and a set of Jane Austen novels printed in the 1920's.

A number of other small books have recently been released or are soon to be, including: "Kitchen" (Grove Press) by Banana Yoshimoto, "Written on the Body" (Knopf) by Jeanette Winterson, "A Mother's Love" (Nan A. Talese/Doubleday) by Mary Morris and "Vertigo Park and Other Tall Tales" (Knopf) by Mark O'Donnell.

Publishers and booksellers say that the smaller size should not be used indiscriminately, adding that this format should reflect the contents of the book rather than being used only as a marketing ploy or it will cease to be effective.

Three of the current best-selling small books demonstrate the successful chemistry of size and content. "The Bridges of Madison County" is about a four-day love affair between an Iowa farm wife and a photographer passing through town, and the

"Einstein's Dreams" is a physicist pondering the time as he works as a patent lawyer and the fantasies in the book are suited to a whimsical size.

"Like Water for Chocolate" is subtitled "A Novel in Miniature With Recipes, and Home Remedies," is a doomed love affair, and the book begins with a recipe. "It can be a wonderful size, the volume both reads like part-diary, part-recipe."

"It can be a wonderful size, the volume both reads like part-diary, part-recipe," said Elai celli, owner of Book Passage in Corte Madera, Calif. "But that publishers don't kill the books by overdoing it."

Having discovered, or rather the appeal of the small publishers say they have experiment with other odd sizes will entice readers to at through the pages.

Knopf and Pantheon lead in this design innovation. "The History" (Knopf) by Donna had the best seller last fall, had se

